

IMPACT: ECONOMIC FORECAST: AFRICA & AUSTRALIA

Africa

Africa with \$2.8 trillion dollars in GDP is the fifth largest continental economy in the world. Africa resides 1.5 billion people with an expected population growth of 2.5-3% in 2026. The continent faces regional disparities in almost every economic aspect from growth to unemployment to poverty. However, Africans are heavily pushing towards urbanization with an estimation stating that over 50% of Africans will live in cities by 2035 creating a strong demand not only in infrastructure, consumption, trade and energy but also in formal employment, fair wages and elevation from extreme poverty.

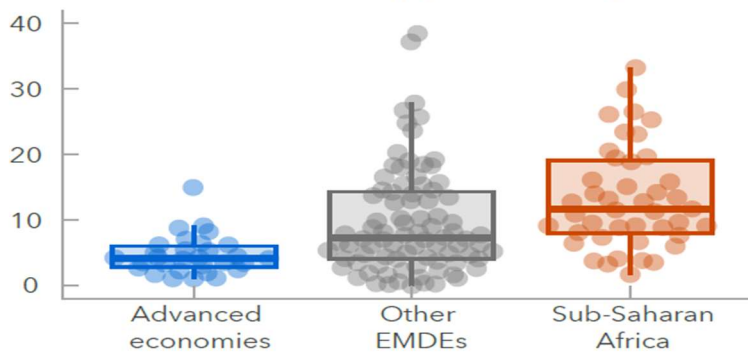
Summary of the economy:

According to a report from KPMG Africa, the anticipated GDP growth for Africa stands at 3.9% in 2025 and 4% in 2026 despite the uncertain geopolitical trade policies and pressures, aid cuts and domestic difficulties. Around 41% of African economies are expected to grow at rates of 5% or higher, nearly double the global average showing a resilient recovery. On the other hand, Africa's median Inflation is projected to continue its disinflationary trend since 2024 to stabilise at around 4% in 2026. The Sub-Saharan region is home to around 1.26 billion people (80% of Africa) and has the youngest population. Consequently, the SSA region is struggling to create formal employment for its youth which then undertakes informal employment enhancing extreme poverty in the region (46% in 2025)

The debt to GDP ratio for Africa is expected to remain elevated in 2026 at around 60-64%. The borrowing conditions have improved in 2025 with easing rates, increase in foreign investments and a weaker US dollar but the sovereign yields and debt rollover risks remain high in SSA as per the International Monetary Fund. Additionally, the region is vulnerable to high debt servicing costs to revenue with a median of 12% in 2025-27.

Figure 4. Interest Payments to Revenue, 2025-27

(Percent of revenue excluding grants, average)

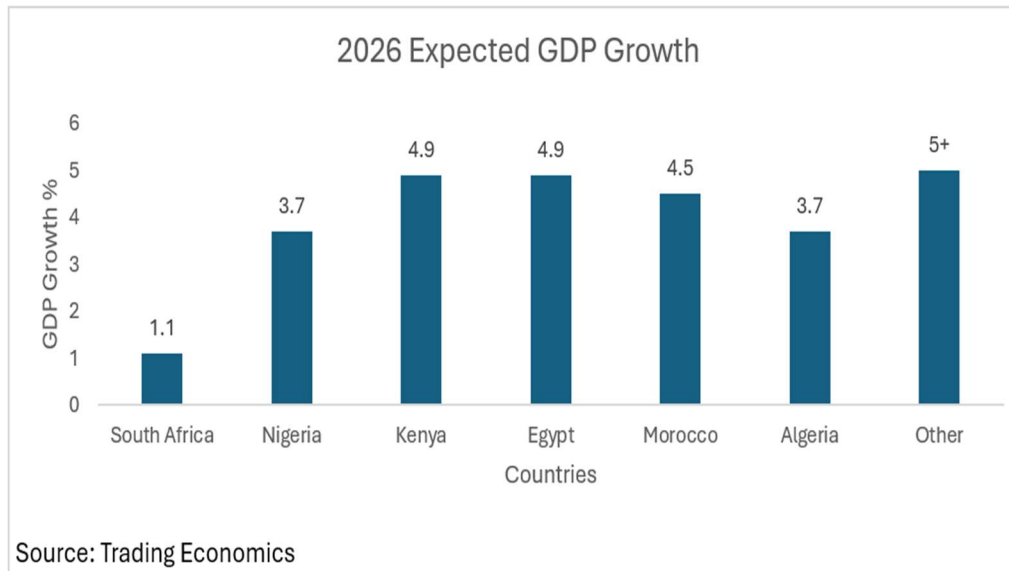


Source: IMF, World Economic Outlook database.

GDP/ GDP Growth:

As per the World Bank, the Sub- Saharan region of Africa projects a GDP growth of 4.3% in 2026 amidst global slowdown and challenges cementing its place as the second fastest growing economy in the world after Asia. South Africa's structural challenges restrict GDP growth to 1.1% in 2026 while Nigeria and Kenya are expected to grow firmly at 3.7% and 4.6% respectively. North African countries face mixed trends in GDP growth with the larger and stronger economies of Egypt and Morocco stabilizing themselves with a steady 4.9% and 4.5% GDP growth in 2026 as Algeria expects a 3.7% growth boosting its importance in the MENA region.

Niger, Senegal, Ethiopia and Rwanda are all expected to end 2026 with a splendid growth of more than 5% which is meaningfully significant in battling poverty and enhancing transformational change given their size and demographics.

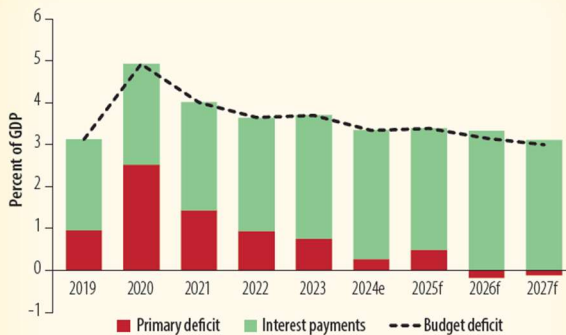


Contrastingly, about 40% of Sub-Saharan Africa is expected to live below the International Poverty Line. The World Bank notes that a 1% increase in GDP per capita only reduces poverty by 1% in the Sub-Saharan region versus 2.5% globally.

Meanwhile, the primary deficit has continuously narrowed down from 2.5% of GDP in 2020 and is expected to end 2026-27 in a primary surplus of 0.1% of GDP for the first time in 7 years (post pandemic recovery). Moreover, the overall budget deficit is expected to decline to 3.1% of GDP in 2026-27 from 3.7% of GDP in 2023 highlighting a gradual decline in the deficit.

However, even though the revenues and non-interest expenditures level with time, the overall budget deficit faces persistently high interest payments on public debt. The high interest payments are expected to continue to trouble Africa in 2026 and 2027 hindering with strong economic growth

Figure 1.20: Budget and Primary Deficits in Sub-Saharan Africa, 2019–27



Source: World Bank projections.

Note: The figure presents GDP-weighted averages for the region. Interest payments are on net outstanding public debt. e = estimate; f = forecast; GDP = gross domestic product.

Interest rates:

After years of high inflation, there are gradual signs of positivity for the continent however there is no complete relief as energy, logistics and wage costs remain elevated and the geopolitical and trade stance remains uncertain. The surge in consumer prices that forced higher interest rates across Africa is finally easing and overall, this has allowed the central banks to revive economic growth in 2025 and moving into 2026. Kenya's current interest rate sits at 9.5% from 11.25% through seven consecutive rate cuts in 2025 and expected to decline further to 9% in 2026. Nigeria cut rates by 50 basis points to 27% in September of 2025 but expect to enjoy a significant rally in early 2026 down to 25%. South Africa and Egypt are expected to hold their diligent outlook towards their economies in 2026. Both economies expect reductions in respective interest rates by 75 basis points and between 600 to 1000 basis points respectively by the end of 2026 and still see inflation to be in control and in their target ranges.

Countries	Expected Interest Rates in 2026
Morocco	1.75%
Algeria	2%
South Africa	6%
Kenya	9%
Egypt	18%
Nigeria	25%

Inflation:

The continent's current trend is of deflation and is expected to remain the same in 2026 with the median inflation being at around 4% whereas the average inflation being at around 13% in 2026. These averages are skewed by a few high inflation countries including Nigeria, Sudan, Zimbabwe and Egypt which struggle with fiscal changes. Morocco, Algeria and South Africa are the stabler countries with inflation levels expected to stay in the lower single digits of 2 to 5% in 2026.

South Africa, the most influential economy in Africa adjusted its inflation targets to 3% from the previous 3-6% range for the first time in 25 years. The economy aims to achieve the 3% target by 2027 gradually creating room for interest rate cuts in 2026.

A decline in global energy and oil prices is expected to help certain smaller economies in Africa to ease inflationary pressures while oil-exporting countries like Nigeria expect lower revenues. Moreover, domestic challenges like natural calamities and internal conflicts are expected to keep the food prices stubborn and high in 2026.

Trade:



Despite being termed as the “crown jewel of the world”, having vast and rich resources across the continent, Africa struggles to take advantage of it and continues to be a net importer since 2014. The continent was an importer in 2025 and we expect the same in 2026.

Afreximbank says that African trade is expected to grow by 5.4% in 2026 and 5.6% in 2027. The trade has reached USD 1.5 trillion in 2025 and is expected to grow to USD 1.7 trillion beyond 2026. African intra-trade has also been growing at a pace of 6.6% annually. The

trade outlook for service sector remains cautious growing to 2.1% in 2026 from only 1.3% in 2025.

The African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) has been ratified by 49 countries in the continent in September 2025 with the aims of catalysing internal trade in 2026 which currently only accounts for 15% of the trade activity in the continent lagging significantly when compared to Asia which stands at 50%.



Nigeria remains Africa’s largest oil and gas producer. South Africa is the mining capital and the largest exporter in the continent expected to contribute approximately USD 140 billion in exports. These 6 countries account for more than 50% of total exports in the continent with heavy dependence on oil, gas and petroleum.

Conversely, machinery, capital goods and pharmaceuticals are regular imports with South Africa at the heart of it closely followed by Morocco and Egypt. These imports help meet the growing urban demands of the developing population. In 2026, the trend seems to be similar with a modest growth in imports and a higher growth in exports.

Country	Primary Export Drivers	Primary Import Category
South Africa	Mining, Vehicles	Machinery, Chemicals
Egypt	Natural Gas, Textiles	Foodstuffs, Mineral Products
Morocco	Automotive, Phosphates	Energy (Crude), Wheat
Algeria	Hydrocarbons, Mining	Capital Goods, Wheat
Nigeria	Crude Oil, Natural Gas	Industrials, Machinery

Kenya	Tea, Coffee, Horticulture	Fuel, Iron & Steel
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China- Africa's Largest Bilateral Creditor:

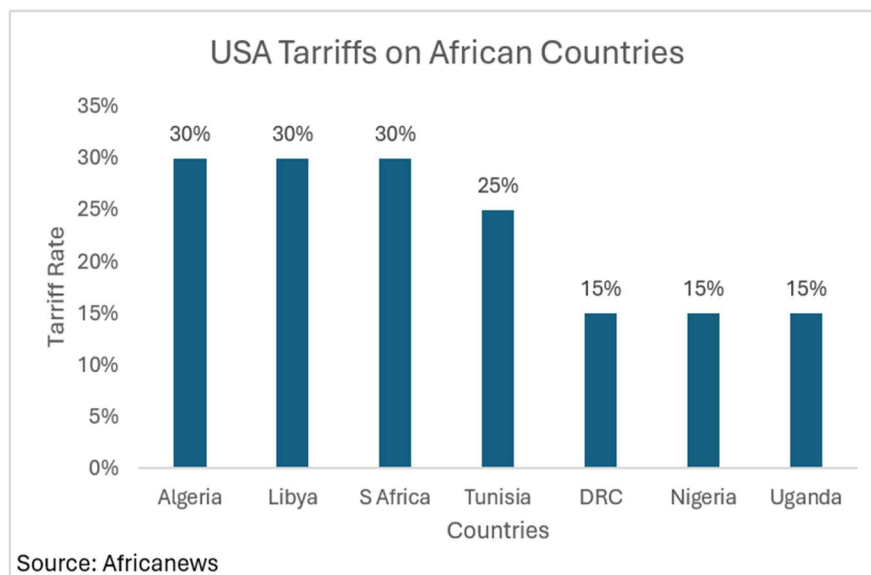
Over the last decade, China has increasingly become the largest bilateral creditor (government to government) of Africa with respect to infrastructure and development projects. Angola, the largest African debtor to China owes approximately USD 17 billions of which about USD 8 billion is collateralized by oil reserves (repayment through oil exports). However, the country plans to reach its zero debt to China goal by 2028 to redirect money flows into domestic development. As a part of a greater Chinese strategy of internationalization of the Yuan and political leverage as claimed by South Africa's central bank governor, Lesetja Kganyago, a lot of developing countries aim to convert portions of their debt owed to China in Yuan, away from the US dollar in order to take advantage of short term interest reliefs as the current prime rate of Yuan is 3% while that of the United States is 7.5%. Kenya converted three dollar denominated loans from their Standard Gauge railway project worth USD 5.08 billion and in turn is expected to save USD 215 million annually starting 2026. Ethiopia aims to convert a portion of their USD 5.3 billion Chinese debt as soon as possible for the same cost-efficiency reasons.

Sudanese Civil War:

The war in Sudan between Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and Rapid Support Forces (RAF) over political control of land continues and has intensified in the last 12 months with RSF dominating the west of the county and successfully capturing El Fasher in October 2025, a major hub in close proximity to Libya and Chad. Over 13 million people of Sudan have been displaced, 9 million within Sudan and 4 million migrating to neighbouring countries like Chad and Egypt. Economically, Sudan's GDP has continuously contracted and has contracted about 42% since 2022 or pre-war levels. Cultivation, the livelihood of the people of Sudan has reduced from 18 million hectares of land to only about 7 million hectares since 2022 triggering a famine in the country. In 2026, we expect Sudan to recover through economic activities as political parties agree to resume oil production in the West of the country. The expected real GDP growth is expected at 9.5% while inflation is expected to lower to 41.5% in 2026 from 49% in 2025.

USA Tarriff Implications:

South Africa may see a 0.1% to 0.3% reduction in its GDP in 2026 due to the new 30% tariff plus the 25% it already faces on its automobile exports. Algeria and Libya are the two other countries which face 30% reciprocal tariffs going into 2026. In 2024, the US imported around USD 53 billion in goods and services from Africa and the first half of 2025 saw a growth of approximately 32% YoY. This surge comes from the increase in demand of bullion and precious metals and cocoa. 22 countries in total face tariffs however the trade relations between the US and Africa remain fragile on the hopes of negotiation as we wait on the supreme court's final decision on President Trump's tariff regime.



2026 Elections:

Various countries across Africa are set to hold elections in 2026 of which the general elections in South Sudan, Uganda, Nigeria and Zambia and the presidential elections in Djibouti stand out. South Sudan's long due nationwide elections are expected to take place in December 2026 however a lack of political framework, refugee migration and oil concerns have neighbouring implications and calls for stability. Nigeria's plan to stabilise its economy is reliant on the electoral outcome in 2026 as the country faces high poverty and inflation. Uganda plays a major role in the African Union and is important for regional security putting more focus on its political outcome. Other countries holding elections include Djibouti, Cape Verde, Cameroon and the Republic of Congo.

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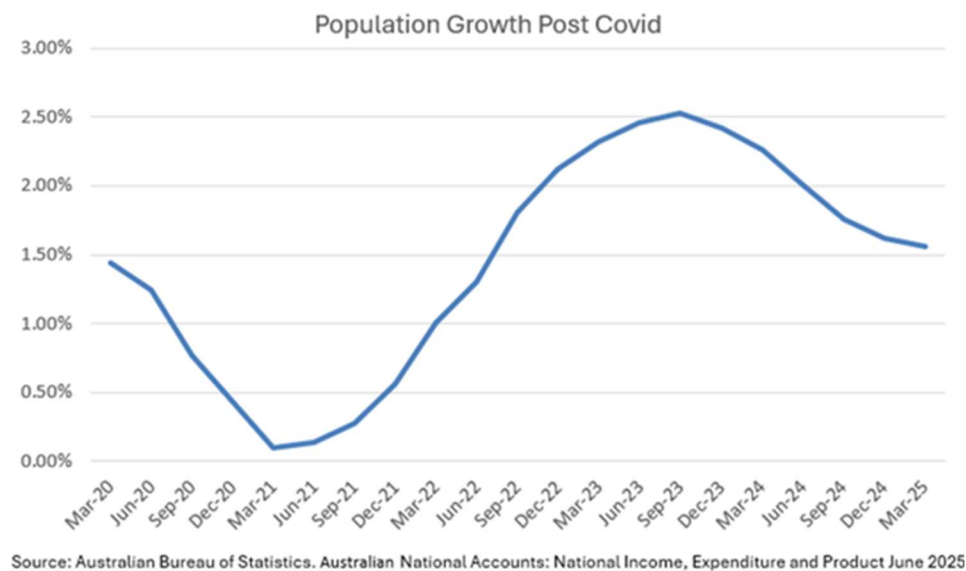
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Australia:

Summary of the Economy:

Australia is the only continent in the world that contains a single country. As of March 2025, the Australian population is 27.5 million. Population growth has been slowing back to pre-COVID-19 levels, settling down from an explosive rebound following the pandemic. This is mainly due to weakening net overseas migration which is the main driver of growth for Australia (Australian Bureau of Statistics [ABS], 2025).



Australia is renowned for its tourism industry. In the 2024-2025 financial year the tourism industry increased 2% from the previous period supporting 696,000 jobs, and accounting for 4.4% of the labour market (ABS, 2025). Australia has a large mining sector that produces materials for economies across the globe but primarily within Asian markets. The International Monetary Fund ranks Australia as the second highest household debt to GDP ratio at 112% (IMF, 2025). This emphasises the importance of monetary policy for the country considering the effect it has on mortgage payments. World Population Review ranks Australia 7th in human development index (HDI) (World Population Review, 2025) representing a well above average standard of living for civilians. The ASX is the Australian stock exchange, based within Sydney.

Economic Indicators:

The Reserve Bank of Australia [RBA] (2025) is forecasting real GDP growth to be 1.9% year over year in 2026. This forecast is based on private sector growth continuing its rising path

over the second half of 2025. The RBA also project CPI year over year growth to be 3.2% in 2026, with unemployment remaining stable at 4.4% in 2026.

We expect unemployment to rise moderately to 4.7% in 2026, reflecting a movement toward realistic level. Even at 4.7% unemployment remains historically low, indicating a tight labour market continuing to force upward pressure on wages and impacting inflation. As mentioned, the RBA forecasts unemployment at 4.4% which is neutral to current conditions. However, in the RBA's most recent statement on monetary policy release they addressed possible exaggeration of tightness in the market. The RBA stated, "While monthly labour market data can be volatile, it is possible that the labour market adjustment to the earlier period of below-trend growth could be more pronounced than we have forecast" (RBA, 2025, p.57).

As such, unemployment and inflation levels are prone to more volatility than the current outlook suggests, depending on the level on misjudgement by the RBA in throughout 2026.

Inflation:

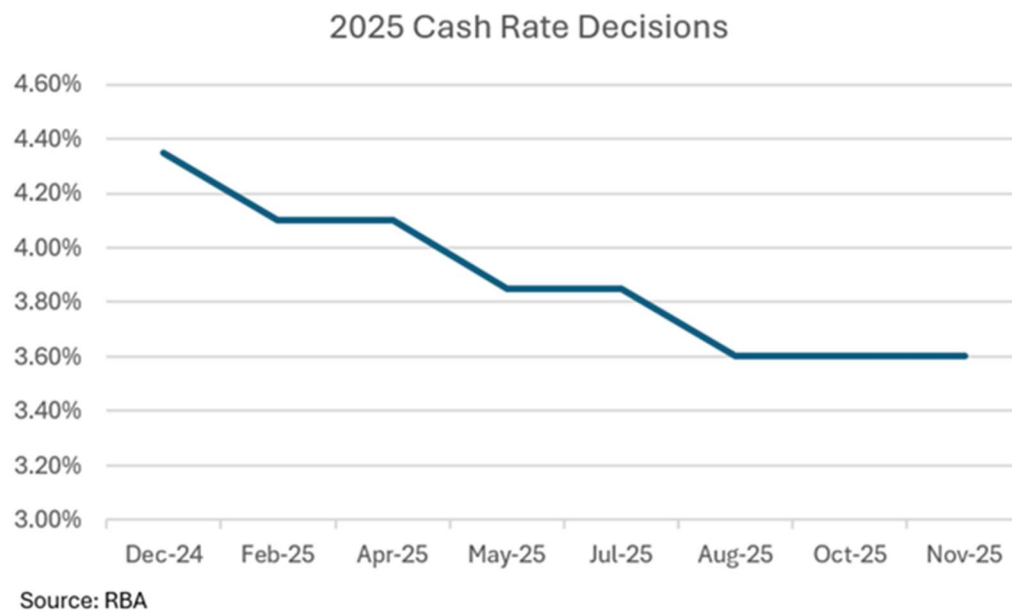
The RBA and the Government of Australia have set an inflation target of 2-3%.

The RBA (2025) recently stated that inflation rose quickly in Q3 and was much higher than the August statement on monetary policy had envisioned. This provided key reasoning for the cash rate being held at 3.6%. They also went on to state that underlying inflation is expected to increase in upcoming quarters above the upper target of 3% but fall back to 2.7% at some point in 2027. We believe that in combination with labour market conditions and recent drive to ease monetary policy, inflation will rise slightly higher than the RBA's previously mentioned projection of headline CPI of 3.2% to 3.3% for 2026.

Interest rates:

The Australian cash rate in recent years was one of stability with very little movement in 2023 and 2024. This was far from the case as the rate has been cut three separate times in 2025 from 4.35% to 3.6% (75 basis points) in totality. Rates were cut consistently in the hopes of recovery in GDP after below trend GDP growth in 2024 and specifically to address the private sector. These monetary easing measures were successful, specifically through boosted household consumption in Q2 (RBA, 2025, p.2). In their most recent meeting, it was decided to hold the rate at 3.60%. They believe the cash rate is much closer to a neutral position after severe easing of financial conditions in 2025 (RBA, 2025, p.3). Due to recent outlook on inflationary pressures acknowledged by the RBA, we believe further

monetary easing comes with much uncertainty. We forecast a hold or slight increase of the cash rate in 2026 lying within a range of 3.60%-3.90%.



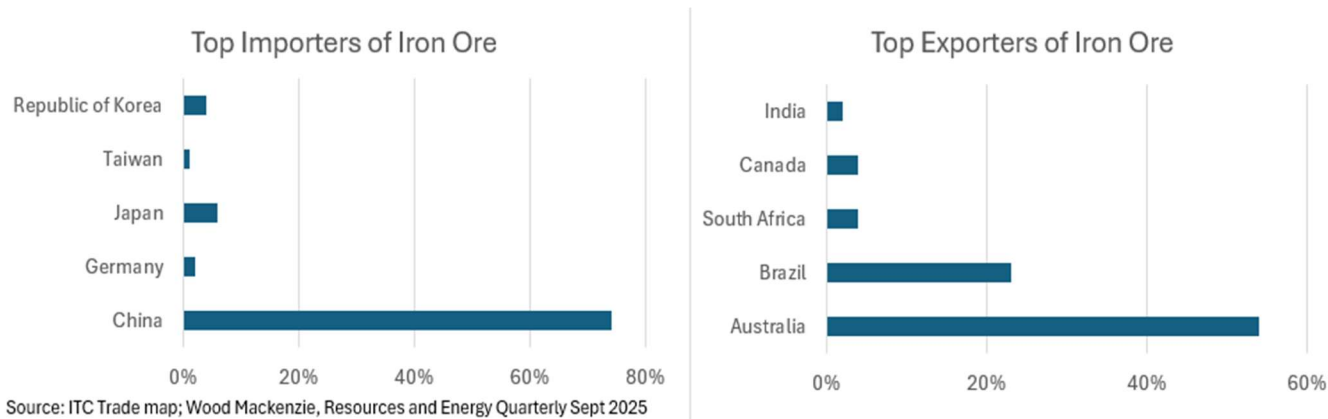
Trade (Imports/Exports):

Australia's top exports include iron ore & concentrates, coal, and natural gas. Their top imports include personal travel, refined petroleum, and passenger motor vehicles (Government of Australia, 2024). All three of their top exports experienced significant declines from 2023–2024, this could be a sign of worse to come.

In 2024 China made up 36% of Australian exports, making it the top importer of Australian goods (Trading Economics, 2025). Sabrina Tabassum, an author for the Resources and Energy Quarterly report of September 2025 highlighted risks posed to Australia. Going on to state that iron ore is expected to have price decreases as more global supply is introduced from primarily Africa (Tabassum, 2025 p.26).

Additionally, throughout 2025 China began to limit its steel use, thus reducing their need for iron ore and coal. We expect this trend to prevail in 2026, as China recently announced steel restrictions aimed to address industry overcapacity (Gemmell, 2025). We expect

these measures will lessen the volume of exports which will be needed to withstand lowering commodity prices. Both factors of price decreases and weakening demand pose major risk to Australia’s top exports. We expect Australia’s reliance on China to prove problematic in 2026.



Using latest 12-month data as a proxy for 2025, Australia ran a goods trade surplus of nearly \$34.00 billion from Oct 2024 through to Oct 2025 (ABS, 2025). We forecast the goods trade surplus to narrow to \$28.90 billion representing a 15% decrease for 2026.



Note: All figures above are converted using a 2026 AUD/USD exchange rate forecast of 0.6825 (MUFG,2025). This presents a forward-looking view of the goods trade balance while still maintaining comparability of previous conditions.

GDP/GDP Growth:

The International Monetary Fund (2025) records Australian nominal GDP at 1.83 trillion USD, and GDP per capita at 65,950 USD. As discussed in the interest rates section, through easing of monetary policy GDP growth has been able to recover in 2025 supported by a boom in the private sector. In Q2 alone, domestic final demand contributed a 0.5 percentage point increase in GDP largely through household consumption (ABS, 2025). Most recent data shows that the household spending indicator increased 5.6% from Oct 2024–Oct 2025, the largest year-on-year increase since Sept 2023 (ABS, 2025).

We are in alignment with the previously mentioned RBA forecast of 1.9% real GDP growth over 2026. Anticipating further growth in the private sector while assessing trade risks and negative price fluctuations of key exports as previously mentioned.

Geopolitical Environment/Conflicts:

Australian-Chinese conflict did not stop at only trade, as in October 2025 Chinese military released flares in the proximity of Australian defence aircraft. Australian defence addressed the matter stating, “This was an unsafe and unprofessional manoeuvre that posed a risk to the aircraft and its personnel” (Australian Defence, 2025).

Further geopolitical concerns stem from AUKUS, an alliance between Australia, United Kingdom, and the United States in 2021. The US Department of Defense states “AUKUS is intended to strengthen the ability of each government to support security and defense interests” (U.S Department of Defense, n.d). Chinese conflict with the US and Australia will require monitoring for possible defence implications and involvement for Australia. Recent friction prevailed with the USA after tariffs on Australian beef were only recently lifted. Reuters (2025) highlights that Trumps tariffs on food products affected Australia greatly, as by 2024 they were the top exporter of red meat to the USA.

Looking to 2026, Australia’s geopolitical and conflict risks are posed almost solely by Chinese trade relations.

Conclusion:

Australia’s outlook is one of modest growth and recovery still stemming from 2024. They face major uncertainty in their exports markets due to pressures on pricing as well as lessened demand from key importers. The private sector has been a positive factor through monetary easing. Australia’s major challenge concerning monetary policy is how to continue this growth while avoiding inflation spikes that they have already acknowledged. Although tight labour conditions currently exist, they may not be as profound to the extent

originally forecasted by the RBA. This leaves more uncertainty for unemployment figures heading into 2026 and several economic indicators.

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